How We Survive Restaurants With a Toddler (Mostly)

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We have a restaurant kit. It lives in the car, in a tote bag, and it has saved more meals than I can count. A spill-proof snack cup of oat crackers. A reusable sticker book. One of those water-reveal coloring pads and the chunky pen that goes with it. Wet wipes — so many wet wipes. A spare spoon, because the restaurant will bring one eventually, but "eventually" is a long time when you're three. And one small new thing from the euro shop, still in its packaging, for emergencies. Last month the emergency thing was a tiny dinosaur. Money well spent.

Here's the thing the kit can't fix: timing. We go at 5:30. Not 6:30, not 7:00 — 5:30, when the restaurant is empty and the staff still like children. We order her food the second we sit down, before we've even looked at the menu ourselves. It arrives while the novelty is still fresh, and novelty is the only currency that matters.

I learned this the hard way, and the lesson was our anniversary dinner last year. We booked the nice Italian place — the one with the candles — for 7:30, because the babysitter cancelled and we thought, how bad can it be? She's usually asleep by 8. She lasted twenty minutes. Twenty minutes of escalating volume, one thrown breadstick, and a moment I'll never forget where she stood up in the booth and announced to the entire restaurant that she needed a wee. We got the pasta to go, ate it cold at home at 9pm, and laughed about it because the alternative was crying.

That night taught me the third rule, which is the hardest one: accept that some meals just won't work. If she's melting before the menus arrive, we leave. No heroic persistence, no "we paid for the table." We ask for the food to go, we go home, nobody's evening is ruined except slightly. Leaving early isn't failure — it's the reason the good restaurant meals stay good.

The kit only works if it's actually in the car, which I learned the one time I forgot it. We were at a pizza place, forty minutes from home, and I realized the tote bag was sitting by our front door. She made it through the meal on breadsticks and sheer novelty, but I aged about three years. The bag

now lives in the boot permanently. It does not come inside. It does not get “reorganized.”

We also stopped ordering her anything adventurous. Every restaurant, every time: plain pasta with butter, or failing that, chips. I used to order her the kids’ chicken thing, hoping she’d expand her horizons. She never did, the food went to waste, and everyone was annoyed. Plain pasta. She’s happy, I’m happy, the waiter is happy.

Mostly, though? The kit, the 5:30 slot, and food ordered immediately. That’s the whole system. It’s not elegant, but last weekend she sat through an entire pizza, drew seventeen water pictures of what I think was a dog, and fell asleep in the car on the way home. I’ll take it.